

shareholders at the last annual general meeting of Tata Power. "Tata Power may partner with Areva SA for projects and has aligned with some major nuclear equipment suppliers," Tata said. He added Tata Consulting Engineers Ltd would also be associated with the nuclear sector. "It's not surprising to have Indian companies getting in touch with us," says Julien Duparrey, a spokesperson of Areva.

Anil Ambani's Reliance Power, which is looking at nuclear energy as another way to boost its presence in the power sector, has also been holding talks with Areva, GE, Russia-based Atomstroy Export for a possible joint venture to manufacture nuclear power reactors. "Once the

FUSION TIME: Somers (centre) with US nuke firms' team in India



necessary legislative changes are enacted, we will develop, in the first phase, 2,000 MW of nuclear power at a cost of Rs 12,000 crore approximately," Ambani said at the 78th AGM of his Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group.

It is not that Indian companies don't have the knowhow but having a tie-up with a foreign expert would go a long way in ramping up their expertise for serving the Indian market better and keeping a door open for exports, explains Kotwal. L&T is looking at GE, Alstom and Siemens as technology partners even as it cements a Rs 2,000 crore joint venture (JV) with NPCIL to build forging facilities to tap nuclear power sector. On its part, GE Hitachi Nuclear Energy (GEH), which

NUKE TANGO
A lowdown on who is talking to whom for collaboration

- NPCIL and L&T joint venture to build forging facilities. L&T also in talks with GE and Westinghouse.
- Tata Power with Areva and other equipment suppliers for generation of nuclear power.
- Reliance Power with NPCIL, GE, Areva and Russia's Atomstroy Export for a possible joint venture to manufacture nuclear power reactors.
- BHEL-NPCIL joint venture to explore technology options with Alstom India for steam turbine generators. BHEL also in talks with Areva.
- ONGC with UCIL for mining uranium.
- NTPC with Thorium Power and GE for setting up nuclear power plants.
- Skoda Power with Atomstroy Export to provide expertise for nuclear reactors.

built the Tarapur units during the 1960s, has gone a step further in sharing with the Government and industry information about its technology offerings and how it might best fit the needs of the Indian nuclear industry. "Should the agreement eventually be endorsed by the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) and adopted by both countries, GEH would be very interested in the business for new reactors as well as in the services sector, such as providing fuel for existing and new units," says Daniel Nelson of GE Infra.

Domestic majors like National Thermal Power Corporation (NTPC), which aims at 6,000 MW of nuclear power generation by the middle of the 12th Plan, is looking at Thorium Power

and Atomstroy Export, a Russian player for technology and fuel, say industry sources.

Among the other nuclear giants, Skoda Power has joined hands with Atomstroy Export to offer technology and expertise for nuclear reactors with turbines from 200 MW to 1,200 MW range. Westinghouse foresees suppliers from India joining the global supply chain for the Westinghouse AP1000 (TM) nuclear power plants. Robert T. Pearce, director, Global Business Development, Westinghouse Electric Company, says, "We are in dialogue with customers and stakeholders, including potential suppliers, throughout India."

The JV between BHEL and NPCIL is likely to forge an alliance with French engineering titan Alstom's subsidiary Alstom Projects India Ltd (APIL) to drive its exploration of the various technology options available for steam turbine generator sets with 700MW, 1,000 MW and 1,600MW capacities.

The size of the opportunity is undoubtedly big. Of India's total installed power generation capacity of 1,44,564.97 MW, nuclear energy makes up for a mere 2.9 per cent. Given the high octane energy crisis it is but natural that India will look to diversify its energy portfolio. Even then it could take 8-10 years for trading in nuclear power to take off after the NSG gives a nod to its members to sell nuclear technology to India. The deal would then have to be passed in the US Congress. Clearly there is still some distance before nuclear power travels the grids and reaches homes and industrial plants. But there is no denying the potential of the idea and the segment. India Inc is obviously excited and has reason to be. Once the steps are through, the deal will fuel a host of businesses—from spin-offs in technology transfers that will happen to equipment manufacturing, to erection of plants and, of course, generation—creating opportunities for both small and big enterprises to profit from. And who doesn't get excited by profits. ■

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